Both sisters, faces pressed close to the glass, watched with a mix of curiosity and apprehension as the train sped deeper into Germany.

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Ten hours later, they heard the screeching and grinding of the train's wheels as it pulled into Berlin. The German escort hustled them between platforms, giving them no time to take in the station before boarding another train out of the capital. Léa read the name on the ticket: *Dresden*. Was Dresden north, east or south? The sisters sat in silence, their German escort at their side. After their reprimand in Metz, they didn't dare speak French aloud.

Disembarking at the massive Dresden-Neustadt station, Léa and Rose clung to one another as they followed their escort off the platform and entered the station's grand central foyer with large arched windows, columns and skylights. Rose, in awe, looked at the walls and ceilings adorned with coats of arms and decorative paintings. They passed many soldiers with bandages on their heads or arms, and some using crutches to help them walk. In corners of the grand hall, tents had been set up as sick bays.

The rumble of voices, the clacking of heels and the screeching wheels stormed up to the dome and echoed off the limestone walls. Disoriented, the sisters hurried after their escort to another platform, where a smaller local train waited.

They disembarked after a few stops and found themselves at a station called Heidenau. Another platform change, and they were on yet another train, this one crept along a river and through a valley with forests and small towns. When the train rattled to a stop, the doors opened onto a single-track station. Their escort guided them outside, where a bone-chilling wind greeted them. The sisters huddled together, trying to stay warm.

"Have we finally arrived?" Rose whispered.

"Yes," Léa said, recognizing the name printed on the platform sign—*Glashütte*—as the same one in their employment contract. A sense of relief washed over her. "We're here."

Their German escort raised his hands, indicating that the sisters should wait outside as he went into the station. It was very cold and damp. Léa put the suitcase down and blew on her hands to warm them. They were in a